Sharing files with external people safely

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Summary

Acme Global employees can share files with people outside the company by using secure links in OneDrive for Business or SharePoint Online. The article explains how to create time-limited, view-only or edit links, enforce authentication, and verify that the recipient can access the file without compromising data security.

Symptoms

- When attempting to share a file externally the user sees the message "Your organization does not allow external sharing" or "Access denied"
- The generated link opens a sign-in prompt that the external recipient cannot bypass
- After sending the link the recipient reports they cannot view or edit the file

Common causes

- External sharing is disabled at the tenant, site, or library level
- Conditional Access policies block unauthenticated access from external users
- The link was created with an expiration date that has already passed
- The file resides in a location protected by sensitivity labels that prohibit external distribution

Overview

OneDrive for Business and SharePoint Online let you share files with people outside Acme Global by generating a secure link. You can choose whether the link grants view-only or edit rights, set an expiration date, and require the recipient to sign in with a Microsoft account or receive a one-time passcode. These controls help keep data within the boundaries defined by our Information Protection policies while still enabling collaboration with partners, vendors, or clients.

Self-Help Procedure: Share a file securely

Follow these steps to create a safe external sharing link from OneDrive or SharePoint. The same process works from the Teams Files tab or directly from the web portal.

1. Open File Explorer (Windows) or Finder (Mac) and locate the file you want to share in your OneDrive-Acme folder or a SharePoint document library.
2. Right-click the file and select Share. In the sharing pane, click the dropdown that currently says "People in Acme Global with the link can edit".
3. Choose "Specific people" if you want to restrict access to certain email addresses, or "Anyone with the link" if you need a broader audience. For most external collaborations, select "Anyone with the link" and then click the link settings icon.
4. In the link settings, set the desired permission: Can view (read-only) or Can edit. Toggle the block download option if you do not want the recipient to save a local copy.
5. Set an expiration date (e.g., 7 days) and optionally require a password or Microsoft account sign-in. Click Apply.
6. Enter the external recipient's email address (or leave blank to generate a link you can copy) and click Send. Copy the link if you prefer to paste it into Teams or email.
7. Inform the recipient that they may need to sign in with a Microsoft account or use a one-time passcode sent to their email.

Verification: Confirm the link works and is secure

After sending the link, verify that the external user can open the file as intended and that the link respects the restrictions you set.

1. Ask the recipient to click the link and confirm they can view (or edit) the file according to the permission you granted.
2. Check that the link expires on the date you selected by attempting to open it after the expiry period - it should display

an "Access denied" or "Link expired" message.
3. If you required sign-in, ensure the recipient is prompted to authenticate; if you chose a one-time passcode, verify they receive it and can complete the challenge.
4. Review the sharing activity in the OneDrive/SharePoint web UI: select the file, click Details -> Activity to see who accessed the link and when.

Service Desk Procedure: Troubleshoot external sharing failures

When a user reports that external sharing is not working, follow this checklist to identify and resolve the issue. Document each step and the outcome in the ticket.

1. Verify the user's license includes OneDrive for Business and SharePoint Online (E3/E5).
2. Check the sharing settings at three levels: tenant-wide (Org Settings -> Services & add-ins -> SharePoint -> External sharing), site collection, and individual library/folder. Ensure external sharing is enabled and not more restrictive than the user's selection.
3. Review any Conditional Access policies that might block unauthenticated access from external users; temporarily disable the policy for testing if authorized.
4. Confirm the file is not protected by a sensitivity label that prohibits external distribution. If a label blocks sharing, either change the label (if permitted) or move the file to an unrestricted location.
5. Test creating a new external link following the self-help procedure. If the link works, advise the user to use the new link and delete any old, expired links.
6. If the problem persists after the above steps, collect the following information for escalation: user UID, file URL, screenshot of error message, timestamp, and any relevant Conditional Access or label policies.

When to escalate

Escalate to the Messaging & Collaboration team if the issue is related to SharePoint/OneDrive external sharing settings, sensitivity labels, or Conditional Access policies that require administrative changes. If the failure appears to stem from a compromised account or potential data leakage, also notify the Security Operations group. Include the user's UID, the exact error message, the file or folder URL, timestamps, and any screenshots of the sharing pane or error dialog.

Keywords: external sharing, OneDrive, SharePoint, secure link, expiration, view only, edit link, guest access, conditional access, sensitivity label, share file outside, share with client